UNIT 4: STRATEGIES FOR SUCCESS

PART II: OBTAINING AND RETAINING WORK

TOPIC 6: BUILDING A NETWORK/REFERENCES

Topic OBJECTIVE: The learner will:

- Understand the importance of having a network of caring adults that can be utilized as references to potential employers, as well as being a source of career guidance

Topic OUTCOMES: The learner will:

- Complete a reference list as an addendum to their resume
- Have up-to-date contact information on a network of adults in their life that they can contact for career guidance
- Contact two potential references and request a letter of reference for their Student Career Portfolio

Topic ACTIVITIES:

Large Group Discussion

Objective: Students understand the meanings of the terms "personal network" and "references" and understand how they are both important tools for success.

Time: 20 minutes

Materials: Handout: "Who Could be in my Personal Network," pens/pencils

Ask students what they think a "personal network" might be in terms of finding a job and working on other transition activities. Define a "personal network" as a group of caring adults that know you as a person, and want to help support your success as a young adult in the community. Explain that a network can be very valuable, because of the insight, experience, contacts, and knowledge a caring adult can give a young person. Being new at finding a job, housing, education, and other steps toward independence can be confusing, and having a supportive adult "on your side" can make a huge difference.

Ask students if they have heard the terms "references" (in relation to employment) and what they think that might mean. Clarify answers and explain that people from your personal network can serve as references to speak to potential employers on your skills and positive traits. Explain that employers may ask for written references, or may want to speak to the referring person on the phone.

As you go over the sheet "Who Could be in my Personal Network," brainstorm with the class other types of people who may be a personal network member and potential job reference, and have them write their answers down in the blank spaces. Also remind them that, if possible, it is good to let someone know you would like to list them as a reference, so that they are prepared to talk to employers about your skills, values, etc.

Writing/Reflection/Assessment

Objective: Students will know how to research and contact adult individuals who can be allies, supports, and job references for them in their job search.

Time: 20 minutes

Materials: Handouts: "Reference Worksheets" and "Sample Reference Sheets," computers with internet access, phone books, telephone access, pens/pencils

Instruct youth to use phone books, the internet (the white pages online, etc.), and phones to fill in the data for their "References Work Sheet." Have them try to fill in the information for at least three people they think could be helpful. Use the "Sample Reference Sheet" handout as a guide.

Technical (Mass CIS)/Research

Objective: Students will type their chosen references in a professional format, with up-to-date information.

Time: 20 minutes

Materials: Computers with internet connection, index cards with students' Mass CIS log-in information, paper/printer, phones

Log on to Mass CIS (www.masscis.intocareers.org). Ask students to select the "My Mass CIS Portfolio" link at the top of the page, and then select the "My Education and Work History" link on the left, followed by the "References" link. There, they will find a template where students can fill in their reference information. Ask students to save the completed list in their electronic portfolio, and print this out for their Student Career Portfolio. Ask students to begin contacting some of their references to ask for letters to assist with their job search.

Who Could Be in My Personal Network

Case Workers
Trainers
Clergy
Clinicians
Staff from Camp or Community Center
Teachers
Past Employers
Neighbors
Education Liaisons
Coaches

_____
_____
_____
_____
_____
_____

When Asking Someone from your Network to be an Employment Reference:

- Teachers, trainers, and coaches are all very good references. They know about your education and training. They can report on your attendance.
- Clergy often deal with personal aspects of your life, not work related areas. However, they know a positive side of you and are respected in the community.
- A reference should be someone who can tell an employer what kind of worker you are.
- It is best to ask people ahead of time, if they would feel comfortable giving you a good reference. Be sure to let them know the positions for which you applied.
- References need to be updated. Addresses, phone numbers, and job titles often change.
- You should use your references' business addresses and phone numbers if possible.
- It is best to use references who are working, rather than unemployed.
- The people who are your references need to have good telephone communication skills. They also need to have telephone numbers where they can be reached during "business hours." Most employers contact references by telephone during the day.

Adapted from Merging Two Worlds, 2003

References Worksheet

Your Name

Your Street Address

Your City, State, Zip Code

Your Area Code, Telephone Number

Fill in the spaces below with information on three people you will use for references.

Reference's Name, Job Title

Business Name

Business Address

City State Zip Code

( )

Telephone Number

Reference's Name, Job Title

Business Name

Business Address

City State Zip Code

( )

Telephone Number

Reference's Name, Job Title

Business Name

Business Address

City State Zip Code

( )

Telephone Number

Adapted from Mass CIS www.masscis. intocareers.org

Sample Reference Sheet

John B. Harding
123 Washington Avenue
Homewood, Illinois 12345
(123) 456-7890

REFERENCE SHEET

PROFESSIONAL REFERENCES

Jan Miles, Operations Manager
Shorewood Manufacturing, Inc.
123 East Muncie Avenue
Shorewood, Illinois 12345
(123) 456-7890
e-mail: jmiles@shorewoodmanufacturing.com

Carl J. Walker, Director of Human Resources
Ace Hospital Supplies, Inc.
789 Tanaka Circle
Freeport, Illinois 12345
(111) 111-3333
carl.walker@acehospitalsupplies.com

William T. Gannon, Shop Supervisor
Rail Cars Express
900 Smithton Street
Seaside, California 12345
(111) 111-4444
william.gannon@railcarsexpress.com

PERSONAL REFERENCES

Gary Turner
777 East Westgate Lane
Seaside, California 12345
(123) 444-8899
gturner@yahoo.com

Mary Snow
235 Frankfort Avenue
Shorewood, Illinois 12345
(111) 577-9999
marysnow235@gmail.com

Sheila Bell
455 3rd Avenue South
Freeport, Illinois 12345
(111) 222-8888
sheilabell@comcast.net